

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, June 17, 2020, at the Claremont Savings Bank Community Center, 152 South Street.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:31 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager
Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

Karen and Perry spoke on behalf of the Visiting Nurse and Hospice of Vermont and New Hampshire (VNH). They gave an overview of what the VNA does for Claremont, including home care, hospice and long- term health care. They said they haven’t received an appropriation from Claremont in a long time. Springfield has given \$65,000 and Lebanon has given \$50,000. They are asking for \$5,000 from Claremont to help offset their \$120,000 costs per year. Mayor Lovett said this would be discussed later in the budget discussion.

OLD BUSINESS

Budget Discussion

This meeting was called in order for the Councilors to get answers to the questions they had regarding the budgets that were presented on May 30th, and to tentatively approve (TA) the budgets, not already TA’d, ahead of the budget hearing scheduled for June 24th.

(Note: Mayor Lovett had distributed her notes from the 5/30 Council meeting to the Council and they were used as references for each of these budgets to be discussed tonight.)

Planning & Development – TA as is for the operational expenses at full staffing/Further discussion on capital project to be had.

Nancy Merrill, Planning and Development Director, talked about the Pleasant Street project and the proposed change to the Truck Route. She said an engineer will give a presentation at the July 8th Council meeting. She said the preliminary plan for Pleasant Street will be to make it a one way with head-in parking, expand sidewalks, and expand lighting and walkway areas. She said she met with the building owners about the plan. The original plan shows about 112 additional parking spaces. The project is estimated to cost \$4.5 million and will include roadway, water, sewer and streetscape. \$3.1 million is for the road and \$2 million is to reconstruct Opera House Square to Glidden Street. They will reconstruct the roadway drainage system. There is an additional \$500,000 for Broad Street. This estimate includes concrete sidewalks and the City will look for public input on that. The engineer will have a public hearing before going with a final design.

Mayor Lovett said the proposal from the City Manager was to use funds that would be available after three bonds are retired.

Mr. Morris said the City will look for approval of the bond after the budget process. However, if Council doesn't approve the bond, the City may need to add \$150,000 to the budget to keep engineering moving forward. The conservative estimate for the new bond will be about \$26,000 over what the City is paying now. He said he's looking for a majority of the Council to be willing to talk about this. He's hoping for a bond vote in August.

Ms. Merrill said the steam heat project that was proposed a few years ago is no longer being considered because the price of oil came down, so that didn't work for the project.

Mr. Morris said the roof drains are draining into the City's sewer system and that has to be addressed. A large majority of the project are things that need to be done anyway.

Mayor Lovett asked to confirm Councilors were okay with the Planning and Development budget. Councilors agreed.

General Services – TA with a 10K decrease for a total of \$904,869 (Note: Loan transfer to Downtown TIFD changed to \$130,930)

No discussion. Councilors agreed with \$904,869.

Fire Department – TA 6-3 at \$2,529,197 (Note: reflects a 4.9K reduction to the total expenditure. Further discussion needed on staffing. Staffing contributes to ISO. Every additional firefighter costs 105K salary and benefits).

Ms. Walter said she had a different number and Fire Chief Bryan Burr's number was correct, so she asked to reduce it by \$4,900.

Regarding staffing, Chief Burr said it would cost \$116,000-\$120,000 to hire someone who needs to be trained. In 2013-14, Council approved accepting a SAFER (Staffing for Adequate Fire and Emergency Response) grant, but there was no support when the grant ended, so the Fire Department lost those people through attrition.

When asked, Ms. Walter said \$120,000 on the tax rate would be 16 cents.

Mr. Morris said there are staffing needs throughout the City (i.e. Police, Library). The City is in the middle of a compensation study. It is important to adequately compensate current employees before adding more people.

Chief Burr said regarding safety for firefighters, with three people on a shift, two go into a burning building with no back up. A lot of times they have to decide whether or not it is safe for them to enter.

Mr. Damren said with four crews and adding one person per crew, would be 64 cents on the tax rate.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to direct the City Manager that after the completion of the Compensation Study to move forward with an RFP for a staffing study.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Council tentatively agreed to \$2,529,197 for the Fire Department budget.

Streets & Roads – TA 6-3 at \$3,403,172 (Note: reflects \$1,500 in additional training money).

There was discussion about the Public Works request for \$750,000 for roads and the City Manager's proposal of \$650,000.

Mr. Morris said with COVID-19 there are still a lot of unknowns, so in trying to find a balance, his proposal was \$650,000.

Council agreed to TA \$3,403,172 for Streets & Roads.

Library – TA at \$403,442 (Note: reflects \$1,500 addition to reconcile expenditure omission. Discussion occurred about regaining 1 full-time position).

Mike Grace, Librarian, said after listening to the Fire Department discussion, his position was not more important than a firefighter. It would be about \$65,000 for one person.

Ms. Kier thinks this is a very important position and is in favor of adding it.

Mr. Morris said it would be 3 cents on the tax rate.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Sweetser to tentatively approve the Library budget for \$403,442.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - no

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-1.

Cemetery – TA, but need to revisit after exploring alternative funding to repair Pleasant Street Cemetery gates/pillars. Question raised and City Manager confirmed that \$8,000 from Cemetery Trust Funds could be used for this item).

Mr. Morris said there is a capital maintenance line that can be used for capital maintenance of the cemetery. \$8,000 can be used from that line to build the gate pillars. He recommended the \$2,000 that was in the Mountainview Cemetery road is ordinary maintenance and is not a capital maintenance item. There is \$68,804 in the Cemetery Capital Reserve. Council agreed with that.

Ms. Walter said you have to gross appropriate, so you will increase Revenue \$8,000.

Mr. Morris said the expenditures stay the same, but the revenue comes from the Capital Reserve, not from the tax rate.

Parks – (Note: okay regarding director’s \$6,400 request for seasonal worker to help with mowing).

Mr. Damren asked to hear about Temporary/Seasonal for mowing.

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, said for Parks, they currently have one full-time person and two part-time people, plus Tim Hernon, who is Parks & Facilities. He gave a brief explanation.

Council agreed to TA the City Manager's proposed amount of \$390,974.

Water Enterprise Fund – TA 5-4 as is and Sewer Enterprise Funds – TA 6-3 as is.

Council agreed to tentatively approve the Water and Sewer Enterprise funds as proposed by the City Manager.

Ms. Walter said with the changes proposed by the Council, there will be an \$11,900 decrease (\$10,000 from General Services, \$4,900 from Fire, \$1,500 added to Streets and Roads, and \$1,500 added to Library). That is \$17,351,374 General Fund expenses with changes made. Revenue is \$5,983,457, including the \$8,000.

Mayor Lovett said the budget will be presented to the public on June 24th.

Mr. Damren said within the first six months of the fiscal year, he would like to see what the budget line items would look like to consolidate Parks and the Claremont Savings Bank Community Center.

Ms. Matteau said regarding the \$90,000 that was put into the budget to be available after the compensation study is complete that she would be in favor of cutting that amount in half.

Mr. Morris said the money is under compensation, for the Council to decide what it would like to do. It would take \$30,000 just to add 1% to the Merit Plan, so Citywide, \$90,000 is not a lot to address the compensation plan. He sees it as a bit of a buffer. If the COVID-19 situation changes and we need to add some money into that budget, this could be used.

Mr. Contois talked about the State continuing to downshift, and the cost of health care is skyrocketing.

Mayor Lovett said NHMA's position, historically, has been to oppose the downshifting and she has gone to the Statehouse to testify.

Mr. Morris said one thing the City is doing, is meeting with union leaders to look at ways to offer different health care options that can save the City money. We have to wait until January to make any changes.

Councilors had a discussion about the logistics for the next meeting. There were technical difficulties with people being able to hear in this meeting, but it was agreed by the majority that

as long as those technical difficulties could be worked out, the budget hearing would be held at the CSB Community Center on June 24th.

There was a discussion about VNH's request for \$5,000.

The majority of the Councilors were against putting the money into this budget, however they all agreed the topic should be placed on an agenda in the near future for discussion.

There was a discussion about the Code of Conduct and the Censure items that were on the June 24th agenda. Because the budget is also on that agenda, it is expected to be a late night. It was agreed to keep those on the agenda, but if needed, that could be changed that night.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 8:54 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council